

Tuatara

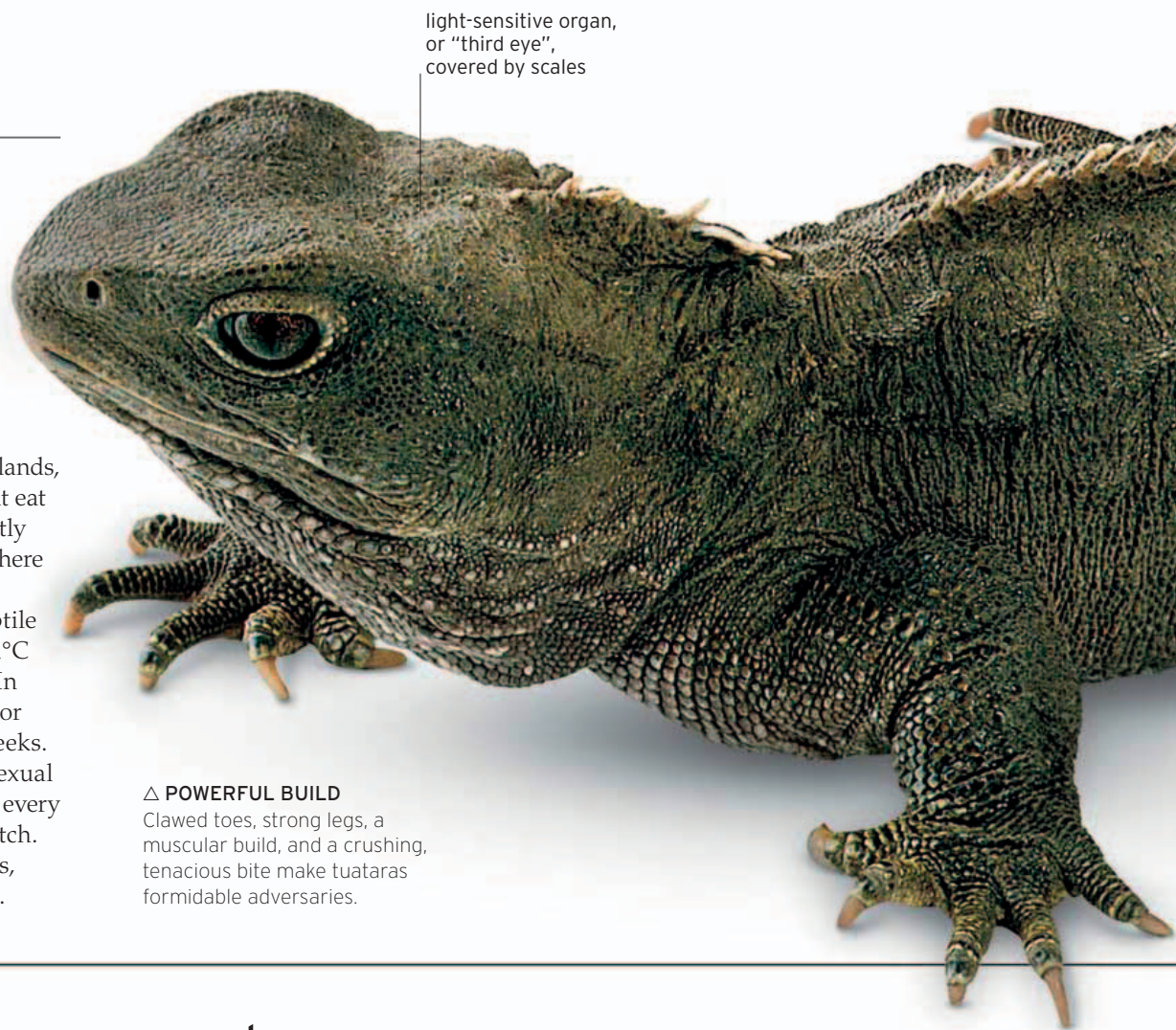
Sphenodon punctatus

Although it looks like a fairly standard if rather chunky lizard, the tuatara belongs to an ancient order of reptiles of which it is the sole survivor. Differences in its teeth, skull bones, and other anatomy—little changed from its group's origins some 200 million years ago—set it apart from lizards and snakes.

Island strongholds

Tuataras inhabit around 30 New Zealand offshore islands, chiefly those without invasive pests such as rats that eat their eggs and young. Breeding tuataras have recently been discovered at a release site on the mainland, where they are protected by a mammalproof fence.

The tuatara is better adapted than any other reptile to a cool, damp climate, remaining active at just 41°C (5°C) and showing heat stress above 77°C (25°C). In winter, it lies torpid in its home burrow—self-dug or usurped from a seabird—sometimes for several weeks. Tuataras have a lengthy breeding cycle, reaching sexual maturity at 10–20 years. Females lay eggs only once every three to four years, which take at least a year to hatch. Juveniles are at risk of being cannibalized by adults, otherwise tuataras may live for more than 100 years.



light-sensitive organ, or "third eye", covered by scales

△ POWERFUL BUILD

Clawed toes, strong legs, a muscular build, and a crushing, tenacious bite make tuataras formidable adversaries.

Auckland tree weta

Hemideina thoracica

This cricket is a common sight in backyards and scrublands. Mostly nocturnal, it spends the day inside burrows—known as galleries—in branches and trunks. Each gallery contains up to 10 wetas, with a single male living with a harem of females and juveniles. The insects enlarge a natural hollow or burrows vacated by a beetle grub, using their powerful biting mouthparts to

snip away the bark. Tree wetas are mostly wingless, although a few grow small wings unsuited to flight. The female has what looks like a large stinger on her abdomen. This is actually the ovipositor, which is used to lay eggs into rotting wood or soil. Both sexes hiss and may bite when threatened, often flicking forward their spiky back legs to scratch attackers.

- ↔ 2 in (5 cm)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🌿 Leaves, fruit, seeds, insects
- 🏠



N. New Zealand

◁ MALE TREE WETA

The male Auckland tree weta has a much larger head and mouthparts than the female, which it uses to defend its harem and gallery from interloping males.



spiky legs used in defense

head twice as long as female's

antennae situated on top of head, palps at side